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Main Reforms in the Education System during the Term of the Twentieth Knesset

This abbreviated outline is submitted to the Knesset Education, Culture and Sports Committee in advance of the commencement of its work during the term of the Twenty-first Knesset. This is part of a series of introductory documents written by the Knesset Research and Information Center on matters of education and culture.

The budget for the Ministry of Education has increased significantly in recent years. Indeed, between 2008 and 2018, there was an overall nominal increase in the budget of some 117%. The major budgetary increases to the education system during the last decade resulted from wage agreements with teacher unions—the New Horizon ("Ofek Hadash") and Courage to Change ("Oz L'tmura") reforms—and additional reforms decided upon in recent years. We present below several of the major reforms advocated by the Ministry of Education during the term of the Twentieth Knesset:

- The Program for Reinforcing English and Mathematics Studies;
- Reducing the Number of Pupils per Class;
- The Program for Bridging Gaps and Advancing Equality in the Education System;
- The Special Education Reform;
- The Second Preschool Teacher's Assistant Reform;
- The School Vacations Program;
- The After-school Education Program.

The Program for Reinforcing the Studies of English and Mathematics

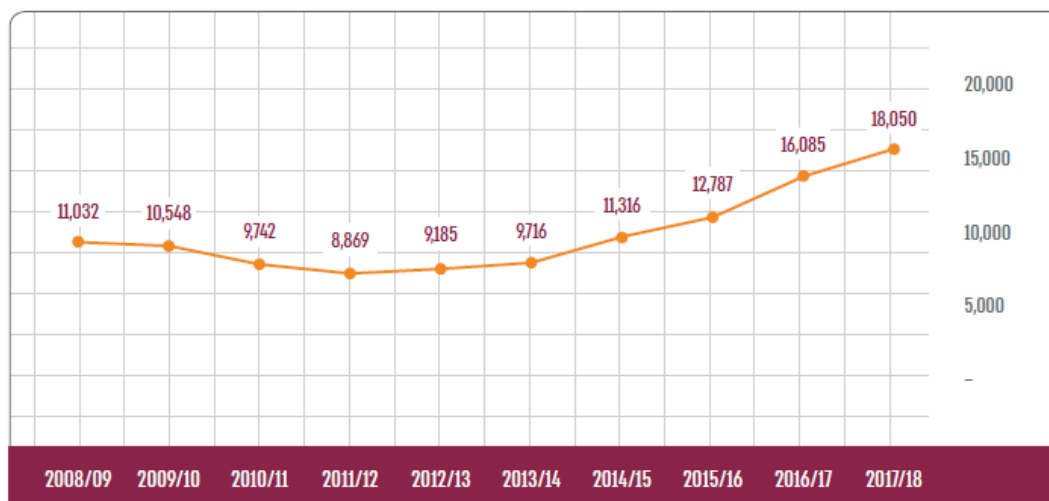
In August 2015, following a decline in both the number and percentage of pupils taking the Bagrut (matriculation) exam in math at the 5–unit level (a 30% decrease between 2006 and 2012), the Ministry of Education announced the launch of the National Program for Promoting Mathematics. The program's primary objective was that the number of pupils studying for a 5-point Bagrut in math would double to 18,000 pupils within four years (i.e., until the 2018/19 school year). The program's components included opening new 5-point math classes, adding classroom and extra study hours for schools, and training teachers.

During the 2017/18 school year, 18,050 pupils took the math bagrut exam at the 5–unit level. One of the objectives that the Education Ministry set forth in its 2019 work plan was to increase the number of pupils taking the math bagrut exam at the 5–unit level, with the goal for the 2021/22

school year being 19,200 test-takers. According to data published in a May 2019 ministry press release, this goal was met already during the 2018/19 school year.

We note that an increase in both the number and rate of pupils taking the math bagrut at the 5-unit level began even before the program's launch. In 2015, some 11,316 pupils in grade 12 were tested in math at the 5-unit level, as opposed to 9,716 pupils in 2014, 9,185 pupils in 2013, and 8,869 pupils in 2012 (the year with the fewest test-takers).

Pupils tested in mathematics at the 5-unit level



During the 2016/17 school year (the last year for which the Ministry of Education published these data), approximately 98% of the pupils who took the math bagrut at the 5-unit level passed the exam. However, the Ministry publishes neither the average grade on the test nor the distribution of the grades (in any case, these grades are not normalized and do not enable a comparison between years), and thus one cannot determine whether these statistics have undergone any change in recent years due to the increase in the number of test-takers.

A study that evaluated the National Program for Excellence in Mathematics during the 2016/17 school year and was published by National Institute of Testing and Evaluation (NITE, Hebrew acronym "RAMA") maintained that the concentrated effort to promote the study of math at the 5-point level constitutes a strategic accomplishment. Nevertheless, the study stated that several question marks are raised alongside the many achievements, including the steps that were taken to attain these results and the toll taken on pupils and schools.

In August 2017, the ministry announced a similar program for advancing English language studies consisting of three main realms: transitioning towards the study of spoken English, increasing the number of pupils taking the bagrut at a higher level, and improving the quality of instruction. The program included a long list of components for each stage of English instruction in school: a video- or computer-based oral Bagrut exam, a 30-hour course in spoken English for all 10th graders,

expansion of the debate program and national competitions, recruitment of 1,000 English teachers, recruitment of 950 fluent English speakers from both Israel and abroad as volunteers in schools, and a higher acceptance threshold for English language studies in colleges.

The ministry aims to increase the number of pupils taking higher-level (4–5–unit) Bagrut exams in English and, to that end, set a four-year goal (i.e., until the 2020/21 school year) of having 70% of all high school pupils take these exams. In the school year preceding the announcement of this program (i.e., 2016/17), approximately 63% of all 12th graders took the higher-level Bagrut exam.

Reducing the Number of Pupils per Class

In 2015, in the wake of the public outcry over school crowding (popularly known as the "Sardines Protest"), the ministry announced a new plan to reduce the number of pupils in elementary school classes. The plan determined that **as of the 2015/16 school year, first graders would study in normative classrooms with a maximum of 32–34 pupils, depending on the school's nurture index** (as compared to a maximum of 32–40 pupils per class before the reform). The plan will expand—i.e., a new age cohort is added every year—until it is fully implemented across all the elementary school grades within five years. During the upcoming school year (i.e., 2019/20), the reform will be applied to grades 1–5.

According to Ministry of Education data, the reform has indeed helped reduce the average number of pupils per class in the regular education system; in the 2017/18 school year there were an average of 27.5 pupils per class as compared to 28.2 in the school year preceding the reform (2014/15). It is important to consider that at that point (the 2017/18 school year) the reform had been applied only to half the elementary school classes—grades 1–3—and that the average number of pupils was 27. It can be expected that the average number of pupils per classroom will continue to decrease as the plan draws closer to full implementation and it is applied to additional grades.

According to a 2018 OECD report, the average number of pupils per class in Israeli elementary schools is much higher than in the OECD member countries overall (27 pupils versus 21). The plan initiated by the Ministry of Education to reduce the number of pupils per class in elementary schools is not expected to yield a meaningful change in this respect.

The Program for Bridging Gaps and Advancing Equality in the Education System

In 2014, the Ministry of Education announced a "program to narrow gaps and advance equality in the education system" for **elementary and middle schools**. The program incorporates a new budgeting model that is not very different from the previous one, though it does include additional hours designated for allocation on a differential basis, depending on a school's socio-economic condition ("nurture basket").

The number of teaching hours designated for allocation on a differential basis increased from 65,000 (approximately 6% of all teaching hours) to 150,000 (approximately 11.5% of all teaching hours) in elementary education; in middle school, the number rose from 32,000 (constituting approximately 8% of all teaching hours) to 90,000 (approximately 19.5% of all teaching hours). Moreover, the allocation ratio was amended to grant higher priority to pupils from a low socioeconomic background. The program was applied gradually beginning in the 2014/15 school year until full implementation was achieved in the 2018/19 school year. The cost of the additional hours is approximately NIS 1 billion per year when the program is fully implemented.

Average budget per pupil, by nurture index quintile (2013/14 and 2017/18 school years, in NIS)

Nurture index quintile	Elementary (Official)			Middle school			High School		
	2013/14	2017/18	Change 2013/14–2017/18	2013/14	2017/18	Change 2013/14–2017/18	2013/14	2017/18	Change 2013/14–2017/18
Weak	16,372	18,891	15.4%	17,623	22,165	25.8%	21,885	28,124	28.6%
Weak-intermediate	16,246	18,183	11.9%	19,378	23,007	18.7%	21,885	28,124	28.6%
Intermediate	15,773	17,410	10.4%	19,210	21,688	12.9%	25,895	32,059	28.8%
Intermediate-strong	14,720	15,890	7.9%	17,535	19,968	13.9%	23,524	3,383	29.2%
Strong	12,633	13,784	9.1%	15,795	17,604	11.5%	21,294	27,969	31.3%
Difference (weak–strong)	29.6%	31.7%		11.6%	25.9%		2.8%	0.1%	

Throughout the period from the 2013/14 school year through the 2017/18 school years, there was an increase in average spending per pupil in every school and across all nurture index quintiles. Nonetheless, in elementary schools, the budget increased at a higher rate for the weak and intermediate quintiles, in accordance with the objectives of the differential budgeting program. The trend was similar in middle schools (except for the intermediate-strong nurturing quintile). However, in high schools, the rate of the budget increase was higher in the two strongest nurture index quintiles than in the weaker ones.

In the 2017/18 school year, funding was allocated differentially to elementary and middle schools on the basis of nurture index quintile, with the exception of the weak nurture index quintile in middle schools. **In the 2017/18 school year, the average budget per pupil in elementary schools was approximately 37% higher in the weakest nurture index quintile than in the strongest nurture index quintile. In middle schools this disparity was smaller (25.9%), and in high school the gap was minute (0.1%).** As previously mentioned, the differential budgeting program does not apply to high schools. Indeed, the budget per high school pupil in the weak nurture index quintile is lower than in the majority of the nurture index quintiles, and it is only slightly higher than the budget per pupil in a school in the strong nurture index quintile.

In order to improve the education system in high schools and to promote budgetary equality between the Hebrew and Arab education systems, the Ministry of Education began a pilot in the 2018/19 school year through which an intervention model is implemented in approximately 100 high schools in the Arab sector. The pilot costs approximately NIS 500 million; it will continue for five years and will be accompanied by an evaluation study. The ministry intends to draw on the conclusions of this evaluation study regarding the effectiveness of the pilot in order to facilitate the expansion of differential budgeting in high schools once the pilot period comes to an end.

The Special Education Reform

Recently, the Ministry of Education has promoted a comprehensive change to the special education system. **In July 2018, the Special Education Law was amended, and changes were made to the process of placement in special education.** Among other things, the amendment established that the pupil's parents will be able to choose whether their child will be integrated into a standard school or be placed in special education. This amendment will take effect gradually: In the 2019/20 school year it will be applied solely in the Northern District, and as of the 2020/21 school year it will be applied throughout the education system.

The reform was granted a budget of NIS 1.2 billion to build 1,150 special education classrooms between 2018 and 2021. It also includes additional allocations of approximately NIS 225 million for standard education in order to support the integration of special education pupils, as well as 2.7 weekly hours for low-functioning pupils who suffer from learning disabilities and behavioral-emotional issues (known as a "personal integration basket"). In addition, the reform includes additional inspector positions for special education as well as additional funding for people to accompany pupils' rides to special education nursery schools.

The reform in the special education system has been the subject of public debate, and it has stirred much criticism and objection from such organizations as the Commission for Equal Rights of Persons with Disabilities in the Ministry of Justice, organizations of parents of children with special needs, and teachers' and principals' unions. The criticism focused on the process by which the reform had been formulated, the nature of the amendment, and the implementation of the amendment and the resources allocated for that purpose.

Once the amendment was adopted, the Ministry of Education launched a website for online consultations to collect suggestions and comments from the general public regarding the integration of pupils with special needs into standard education. According to the website, the consultation takes place in two arenas simultaneously: one for the parents, pupils, and organizations' representatives and another for educational professionals in the field. To date, no insights or decisions made following the consultations have been published on the website.

The Second Preschool Teacher's Assistant Reform

In 2015, a public protest ensued due to the conditions in preschools administered by local authorities. The background to the protest was a 2012 reform by the Ministry of Education to grant free education in public nursery schools to all children ages 3 and 4 (instead of 5 as the law had stated until then). The protestors claimed that the nursery schools had not been appropriately tailored to the children's physical and emotional needs. They therefore demanded increasing the number of educational staff, decreasing the number of children per classroom, properly training the educational staff, and adjusting the preschool buildings and curriculum to the children's needs.

In advance of the 2015/16 school year, the Ministry of Education announced the reform for preschoolers aged 3–4 in public nursery schools (aka the "Second Preschool Teacher's Assistant Reform"). This included funding for an additional teacher's assistant in a public nursery school (both official and recognized but non-official) with at least 30 children in the class, funding for enriching the nursery school's educational environment (only for official preschools), division of the nursery schools into clusters (15 preschools per cluster), and appointing a head preschool teacher in each cluster to provide pedagogical assistance to the educational teams.

The Ministry of Education provides differential funding for the cost of the additional preschool teacher's assistant: 100% of the normative costs of a recognized teaching assistant for each nursery school in authorities belonging to socioeconomic clusters 1–5 and 80% of the normative costs of a recognized teaching assistant for each nursery school in authorities belonging to socioeconomic clusters 6–10. The operators of the nursery school are obligated to employ the additional teacher's assistant throughout the school's activity hours, for at least five days a week (not including the shorter day, if one exists), and not in excess of a full-time position.

Some 5,657 additional preschool teacher's assistants were employed during the 2017/18 school year at the cost of approximately NIS 540 million. That year, approximately 182,500 children attended preschools in which an additional teacher's assistant was employed (approximately 56% of all children ages 3–4 who attended public nursery schools).

The budget for enriching the preschool educational environment in official preschools is also allocated on a differential basis: an average of NIS 5,000 per preschool in authorities belonging to socioeconomic clusters 1–4 (based on the Central Bureau of Statistics index), an average of NIS 3,000 per preschool in authorities belonging to clusters 5–6, and an average of NIS 1,000 per preschool in authorities belonging to clusters 7–10. The funding is given to all preschools for 3–4-year-olds, regardless of the number of children in attendance, though the estimate per preschool is based on a key of 31 children per class. The budget is meant to be utilized to enhance the preschool with items that are on a list provided to the preschool teachers, based on the needs of the preschool and in line with the teacher's common sense. The enrichment component of the Second Preschool Teacher's Assistant Reform was budgeted at approximately NIS 20 million for the 2018/19 school year and has served approximately 215,000 children.

The School Vacations Program

To bridge the divide between parents' and pupils' vacations, the Ministry of Education began the **Nitzanim for Vacations—Holiday School** program, under which, as of the 2017/18 school year, educational institutions will operate a five-day camp during both the Passover and Hanukkah vacations. The program is meant for pupils studying in preschools and grades 1–3 in both the standard and special education tracks. According to the Finance Ministry, the overall yearly cost of the ten activity days is about NIS 400 million. During the 2018/19 school year, approximately a half million pupils (in both preschools and elementary schools) took part in this program during each vacation.

According to the Ministry of Education, this program has currently been suspended. Because the Finance Ministry refused to fund the Ministry of Education on the grounds that a transition government currently holds power, the latter used the money from the program to fund the start of the year in the special education schools. However, the Education Ministry added that once a government is established, it will make an effort to reinstate the funding and regularly increase the budget for special education in accordance with demographic growth.

During the term of the Twentieth Knesset, the Education, Culture and Sports Committee established a subcommittee to examine school vacations, which was chaired by Knesset Member Oded Forer. In July 2017, this subcommittee submitted its recommendations to alter the vacation schedule in Israeli schools and preschools in order to close the gap between the number of vacation days given to workers and the number given to children in the education system. The subcommittee's debate and recommendations predated the launch of the Nitzanim for Vacations program by the Education Ministry and constituted part of the public discourse that unfold concerning this topic.

The After-school Education Program

In the 2017/18 school year, the Ministry of Education expanded its subsidy for after-school programs in all authorities (through a program called **Nitzanim—Subsidizing After-school Enrichment Programs for 3–8-year-olds**). After-school programs in preschools are subsidized solely in local authorities in socioeconomic clusters 1–5. Afterschool programs for children in grades 1 and 2 are subsidized for children in local authorities in all the socioeconomic clusters.

The basic cost of an after-school program is NIS 650 per pupil per month. The subsidy ranges from NIS 150–650 per pupil per month, depending on the Central Bureau of Statistics socioeconomic cluster to which the local authority belongs, and it is given to local authorities that **have chosen** to join the program. The pupils' parents are required to pay the balance. The basic framework of the after-school establishment can be expanded with additional components (hours, extracurricular activities, and staffing) up to a maximum of NIS 935 per pupil per month (with parents being asked to pay the balance).

The program is funded pursuant to Government Resolution 3377, which was adopted in January 2018 and which stipulated that funding for the program would continue until the end of the 2018/19 school year: NIS 905 million were earmarked to fund programs in 2018 and NIS 605 million were earmarked for 2019. In June 2019, the Government decided to amend Resolution 3377 so that the program would continue to operate through the 2019/20 school year. During the 2018/19 school year, approximately 209,000 pupils participated in the Nitzanim program's after-school activities.

Furthermore, in July 2017, the Knesset approved the Supervision of the Operation of After-school Programs Law. In addition to setting out provisions regarding the operation and oversight of after-school establishments, the law establishes that the minister of education must determine a maximum cost that can be charged for the range of services these settings provide. Subsequently, the Ministry of Education published draft regulations that define, among other things, the range of services an after-school establishment provides. The ministry also published a draft of a directive concerning the maximum amount that can be charged, which is based on the services offered—up to NIS 650 for the basic set of services and up to NIS 935 for the expanded set of services. A final version of the regulations and directive have yet to be submitted to the Knesset Education, Culture, and Sports Committee, and they thus have yet to be approved and implemented.

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